

Material is a starting estimate

Foundations

THE IDEA

The familiar values pawn 1, knight 3, bishop 3, rook 5, queen 9 estimate exchange outcomes. They are not rules about who wins. King safety, activity, pawn structure, and forcing threats can outweigh the arithmetic.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Trading a rook for a bishop loses roughly two units if nothing else changes. If that trade removes the last defender of the enemy king and produces forced mate, the arithmetic becomes irrelevant.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

What must you add to a material count before deciding an exchange?

ANSWER AND REASONING

Check the resulting king safety, piece activity, pawn structure, and tactical threats. Count only after including all likely recaptures, not just the first capture.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

Count pieces, then evaluate the position they create.